

The motivation behind this choice remain unknown, however, and much also remains uncertain about the origins and early functioning of the church.

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CELTIC PHILOLOGY AND THE NAME OF LODDON

by Andrew Breeze

Loddon (TM 3698) is a small town 16km south-east of Norwich, where the Beccles road crosses the river Chet. It seems a very English place. Yet its name (also that of Loddon hundred) provides unexpected evidence for the Celts. It occurs as *Lodne* in 1043, *Lotna*, *Lothna*, and *Lodnes* in Domesday Book, and *Lodne* in about 1095 and 1198. This, taken as the old name of the Chet, has been somewhat shakily linked to Old Irish *loth* 'mud, mire', with a possible meaning 'muddy

river'. The Chet would hence once have been a namesake of the Hampshire-Berkshire river Loddon, which flows northwards from Basingstoke to join the Thames near Reading.¹

It is true that the rivers Chet and Loddon are both placid. In *Windsor Forest*, Alexander Pope celebrated 'The Loddon slow, with verdant alders crowned', the mud and damp meadows of which shelter the Loddon Lily (*Leucojum aestivum*), a relative of the snowdrop (and so not a lily but a member of the daffodil family).² As the Loddon Lily flourishes in swamp-like conditions, 'muddy one' might seem an apt translation of *Loddon*. But there are philological objections. Old Irish *loth* 'mud' and Gaulish **luta* 'mud' (thought to give *Lutetia* 'marsh, marshy river', the Roman name of Paris) have no known cognate in British, the Celtic language (ancestor of Welsh, Cornish, and Breton) spoken in Roman Britain.³ Hence the caution of scholars on the explanation 'muddy river'.

This note therefore offers another explanation. It submits that *Loddon* is related rather to Welsh *llwdn* 'young of animal' and Middle Breton *loezn* 'animal'. These are well attested. The 12th-century *Four Branches of the Mabinogi* describe the country near Cardigan, where the hero Manawydan catches wild animals (*llydnot*) in their coverts (the *llydnot* would be hares and roebuck, since an enemy's magic has deprived Manawydan of his hounds). Other instances show Middle Welsh *llwdyn* used of colts, foals, kids, lambs, piglets, fawns, and even chicks; a cognate occurs in the Middle Breton place-name *Caer Lodnic* ('Animal Fort'); but it does not seem used of wolves, foxes, or dogs, so cannot be translated 'whelp' or 'cub'.⁴

It is easy to relate *Loddon* to Welsh *llwdn* on semantic grounds. Many Welsh rivers are named after living creatures. Especially relevant here are streams called *Cenau* 'cub', *Colwyn* 'whelp, young animal' (one of which runs down to Colwyn Bay in North Wales), *Cyw* 'chick', *Hesbin* 'yearling ewe', and *lyrchell* 'young roe'.⁵ All these refer to young creatures. There is hence no problem in explaining *Loddon* in Norfolk and the Thames Valley as a hydronym meaning 'young animal'.

As regards phonology, the situation is as follows. Middle and Modern Welsh *w* normally derives from British *u*. However, British *o* (which usually remains in Welsh) on occasion gave *w* before certain consonant groups, as in Welsh *swllt* 'treasure; shilling' from the Latin loan *solidus* (a gold coin of the Roman empire).⁶ A similar process may have occurred with Welsh *llwdn*. If so, this allows us to link it with *Loddon*, as also with Modern Cornish *lodn* 'bullock' and Scottish Gaelic *loth* 'foal', where original Celtic *o* is preserved.⁷

This explanation of *Loddon* near Norwich and Reading as a Brittonic river-name meaning 'young animal' seems semantically and phonologically sound. If it is, it clears up an old philological problem. It shows a diminutive or familiar name given to the Chet and the Loddon (both small rivers joining large ones), suggesting the Britons had a more intimate feeling for the natural world than the interpretation 'muddy one' would indicate. It offers a glimpse of how the Celts of Norfolk and the Thames Valley saw their world on the eve of Anglo-Saxon occupation. It also reveals without ambiguity a Celtic place-name in Norfolk, which can be added to those of Creak, Lynn, Trunch, Yare, and so on.⁸ As for historical implications, the continued existence of a Celtic toponym implies a Celtic community on the Chet perhaps survived English conquest in the late 5th century (though this is not certain). It may also indicate that the English of the same area survived Scandinavian conquest four centuries later.

Both these points should be treated carefully. It is usually thought that English and Scandinavian invaders alike penetrated the country via the main rivers, away from the Chet; and boulder clay around Loddon would support dense forests of oak and ash, deterring settlers. Alan Davison here points out to the writer that the Lowestoft Till found south of Loddon is a particularly thick

and heavy boulder clay. But he also notes how the Domesday survey shows that woodland by 1086 was to be found in central Norfolk, rather than here. He agrees that the distribution of Scandinavian parish-names in Norfolk, which encircle but do not enter the Loddon region, suggests the Northmen avoided this area.⁹ Yet he adds that a Scandinavian presence in Loddon parish (and other parishes with pre-Norse names) is nevertheless indicated by several minor toponyms in *beck* (<Old Norse *bekkr* 'stream') and *gate* (<Old Norse *gata* 'path, road').

Nevertheless, given the continued existence here of a Celtic toponym, archaeologists and others may still expect to find the persistence of established populations and customs in the hundred of Loddon. Like the Loddon valley near Reading, it would be an area of social and cultural evolution, not revolution.

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2. Geoffrey Grigson, *The Englishman's Flora* (London, 1958), 413–14.
3. K.H. Jackson, *Language and History in Early Britain* (Edinburgh, 1953), 578; A.C. Breeze, 'The Name of Lutudarum, Derbyshire', *Britannia* XXXIII (2002), 263–4.
4. *Geiriadur Prifysgol Cymru* (Caerdydd, 1950–2002), 2234.
5. R.J. Thomas, *Enwau Afonydd a Nentydd Cymru* (Caerdydd, 1938), 52; Coates and Breeze, 133–5.
6. Jackson, 272–8.
7. *Geiriadur*, 2234.
8. Coates and Breeze, 321–2, 363.
9. H.P.R. Finberg, 'Anglo-Saxon England to 1042', in his *The Agrarian History of England and Wales: AD 43–1042* (Cambridge, 1972), 383–525, at 402–3, 470.